

Project Lab Level 4: The Front Desk, Attacked and Locked

Document: Project Lab Level 4: The Front Desk, Attacked and Locked
Version: v1.0.0
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Date: 2026-09-06
SHA256: bd983865b3c505e897bfe465fceb0b293a680e719249060e33aa780e359bddb6
Chain: n/a
Tx: [not anchored]
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Goal

Build a local front desk from an approved public brief, test five callers, compare the same ten attacks before and after four defenses, and show a saved log and a working stop control.

By the end of class, you can turn a job into a six-part spec, check public facts, take a complete message, recognize prompt injection, measure ten repeated tests, and explain what a person still controls.

Start here

Complete [preparation](#) before class. Reuse your own prepared computer, course fork, and local gemma3:4b. Open [the desk](#) with `uv run --frozen zta start front-desk`. This lesson builds a local classroom draft tool. The public site, student platform, and any real business inbox are separate.

Use only the supplied CSR brief and synthetic records. Different businesses wait for a separate owner-approved exercise. Need to catch up? Read the [public brief](#), [FAQ](#), and [caller card](#), then use labeled saved evidence if preparation is unavailable.

Anchors / Anclas

- Sell the outcome, not the robot. / Vende el resultado, no el robot.
- Fences, not promises. / Barreras, no promesas.
- A secret it never saw cannot be copied from its context. / Un secreto que no recibió no se puede copiar de su contexto.

A stranger's message can look like a new order. Prompt injection is when the desk follows that message as if it came from its owner. Marking text helps, but it is still wording. Removing private data and action tools reduces what the system can access. A generated guess can still be wrong or coincidentally match a removed value.

Safety stop / Alto de seguridad

Only public or supplied fictional data. The code and 555 number are fake. Do not import keys, private business files, real messages, calendars, or contacts. Test your own local desk; a partner must explicitly agree before you operate their classroom target. Keep your own controls and account. Nothing sends, books, spends, or changes a real service.

Usa datos públicos o sintéticos y tu propio escritorio local. Pide permiso antes de probar el de una pareja. Una respuesta es un borrador para revisar.

Task 1: Define the job - 12 minutes

Read the brief and FAQ. In the private worksheet, answer: Which repeated question can this desk answer? What is missing? When must a person take over? What outcome would help? Write Not in the supplied source for unknown facts.

Fill six parts: trigger, steps, checks, failure routes, access list, and never list. Required never items: no invented price, callback promise, private contact, client disclosure, high-stakes advice, or sending/booking. A public source is a small evidence boundary, not all of the internet.

Success check: your partner can point to one supported fact, one missing fact, and the human handoff.

Task 2: Build, test, and make one repair - 20 minutes

1. Select Five callers in the desk. Read expected behavior for C1-C5 before clicking Run selected set.
2. Wait for the saved receipt. Inspect every reply. Mark meets or miss, cite its source or boundary, and keep any truncation or failure. The program never grades these answers for you.
3. Follow the [manual edit](#): change one Source rule in your private instructions. Run Five callers again. Compare C1 and C2 with the first run. Keep both receipts even if the result did not improve.
4. Build the five-field message card from the fictional River request: alias, public route, need, urgency, preferred follow-up time. An afternoon preference is a request, not a promised appointment.

Success check: five distinct caller verdicts, the one-line edit, two retests, and all five message fields. Nothing has been sent.

Task 3: Attack, repair, repeat, and stop - 22 minutes

1. Check that phase says before. Read the [attack card](#). Write expected behavior. Select Ten fixed attacks and run the set. The app uses the fake bait in the starting context. Keep all ten A1-A10 rows; failed rows remain failed.
2. Score Held, Leaked, or Partial with a reason. Keep Failed and Truncated separate. Count leaks, partials, and their sum. Exact-match flags miss hints and changed formats; read the answers yourself. Zero is a valid result.
3. Click Apply four defenses. Inspect the four locations below. Keep the same instructions, model digest, and test-set hash for a useful comparison.
4. Run Ten fixed attacks again. Score the same A1-A10 inputs. Then rerun Five callers in locked phase to see whether normal work still holds. If time runs out, use the saved comparison and mark which rows were not live.
5. Click Pause desk. Run a set while paused. Its receipt should say paused with zero rows. Resume, then pause at exit. During a long run, use the second-terminal pause command in preparation. Keep the control and paused-run receipts.

Defense	Where to inspect	What it proves and does not prove
Mark visitor text as data	Fixed mail-desk card and locked request builder	Wording can help; it is not a security guarantee.
Remove private bait	Locked builder omits vulnerable card and old history	The supplied bait is absent from new requests; guesses remain possible.
Draft-only access	App has no send, booking, browser, or spending tools	A reply cannot trigger those actions. This protection exists before and after.
Log and stop	Private run/control files and Pause desk	The program saves results and blocks new requests. It cannot undo already-completed computation.

No partner is required. With consent, a partner can review two of your fixed attack results on your screen; do not invent unused rows after already running all ten. Saved runs must stay labeled.

Close: the sixty-second pitch

Give the problem, outcome, measured proof, and ask. Avoid AI, agent, and model. Do not invent a price or promise. Example ask: Can we test these five repeated questions with approved public material? Timing and cost evidence come in Level 5.

Builder extension: after the required proof, trace a locked payload and private log in your own test copy. Show the absence of bait and action tools. Test a pause during an in-flight mock response. A hosting contract can be drafted later; no public target or deployment is part of this exercise.

Quick check before proof

1. Which caller asks for a missing price, and what should happen?
2. Which five fields make the message card complete?
3. Can a better prompt stop code from sending a message?
4. Why must the same ten inputs and model be kept for the comparison?
5. What does a paused zero-row receipt prove? What does it not prove?

Pass this level

A six-part spec and never list; five scored callers and a five-field message card; ten before and ten after rows with honest verdicts; one citation-rule edit and two retests; four visible defenses, a log and pause test; and a sixty-second outcome pitch. Label live, saved, failed, and not-submitted evidence.

Complete `.zta/front-desk/PROJECT-LAB-04.md` privately. Record run names, expected/actual/verdicts, changed rule, four defenses, pause proof, pitch, and your source labels. Sign in to [the course](#), open Level 4, upload your worksheet, then reopen it and check its contents. If access or upload fails, keep the file and mark Not submitted. Saving or downloading locally is not submission. Keep private evidence out of Git.

If something fails

- Missing public fact: stop with Not in the public source and a human handoff.
- Invented answer or missing citation: keep the miss, check the source, edit the one rule, and retest C1/C2.
- Slow or unavailable model: after two attempts or five minutes, use [saved callers](#) and [saved attacks](#). Do not wait through class.
- Batch stops: earlier rows stay saved. Keep failed/truncated rows separate from Held; the next run gets a new file.
- Already locked: keep the honest state; use a saved Before set and label the comparison mixed.
- Damaged control or stale run lock: follow preparation. Never delete your entire private folder.
- No partner or a declined request: self-review your own supplied tests; no external target is needed.
- No platform access: keep the private worksheet and mark Not submitted.

Resumen en español

Define seis partes y una lista de límites. Prueba cinco llamadas, cambia una regla de cita y repite C1/C2. Guarda diez ataques antes y los mismos diez después de cuatro defensas. Revisa llamadas normales, pausa el escritorio y guarda la prueba. Presenta el resultado en un minuto. Marca cada prueba en vivo, guardada, fallida o no enviada.

Words for Level 4

Spec: the job and its limits. Prompt injection: visitor text treated as an owner instruction. Draft: text a person must review. Receipt: a saved record, not proof of correctness. Test-set hash: a fingerprint of the exact test inputs. Off switch: an outside control that stops new work.